



Keeping faith: Brazil's early elimination from the World Cup has not changed the country's Football Confederation's plans to continue with coach Carlo Ancelotti. REUTERS

Undav had sparked as a super-sub, scoring two goals and providing as many assists. But as a starter against Paraguay, he barely threatened. He failed to register a shot on target and completed just 60 per cent of his passes.

"We keep treating the symptoms. We change the system, the line-up, the players' positions, far too often. We are in a permanent debate about how Germany actually wants to play," Phillip Lahm, the captain of Germany's victorious 2014 side, wrote for The New York Times.

Germany is among the highest-scoring teams in World Cup history. Yet it has struggled to produce elite goalscorers on the biggest stage since Miroslav Klose and Thomas Mueller, two of the icons of the 2014 side.

"... Germany was always at its strongest when it took the individual

quality it had, married it to a robust, assertive mentality, put its best players on the pitch and forged them into a real unit. That is exactly what is not happening. You need a core group to take responsibility," Lahm added.

Lahm's call for "responsibility" could not have been more evident than before the shootout. Leon Goretzka, Waldemar Anton, Nathaniel Brown and Malick Thiaw reportedly refused to take penalties, leaving Jonathan Tah, who had never taken a spot-kick in senior international football, to step up and shoot off target.

Brazil, meanwhile, had different fault lines, although selection remained a major talking point there as well, especially around the country's leading goalscorer in men's football, Neymar.

The 34-year-old former Barcelona

forward walked into the squad after nearly three years, having registered six goals and four assists across all competitions last season. João Pedro, Chelsea's highest goalscorer in the 2025-26 season with 20 goals and nine assists, was overlooked. Legacy, here, outranked form, and that came back to bite Brazil. "I think this elimination starts with the decisions from the bench," Ronaldo Nazario was quoted by Spanish outlet AS. "Carlo Ancelotti is one of the best coaches in football history, but tonight he made too many mistakes.

"I still do not understand why João Pedro was not part of this squad. He has had an outstanding season, he is in form, and Brazil needed a striker who could offer something different."

Injuries and poor decision-making hurt Brazil as well.